

Searching for football fever in New York

Landing at Newark Liberty International Airport offers the first signs that a World Cup is arriving. Yet the mood is nothing like the **festive atmosphere** encountered at earlier editions of the tournament.

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The flight to Newark can sap your energy. Sixteen hours in a closed metal tube with 300-plus strangers for company is hardly an ideal experience for any human being. The initial thrill of reaching a new city, of watching the greatest spectacle in world football, is easily subdued by the claustrophobia and cramped legroom of an international economy flight. The US carrier ferrying me, however, offered far better creature comforts than the desi airline I had taken earlier on the same trip.

Football was not on the minds of any of my fellow travellers. Most were senior citizens visiting their NRI children in the United States, or those very children returning to their New Jersey homes after spending time

with ageing parents. The lovely, mostly octogenarian ladies manned the cabin with aplomb, though the food was as stale as airline food can be. Hours into the journey, I tried hard to follow a banal movie over the assorted sounds of nightly slumber into which the aircraft had descended.

The conversation eventually veered towards football, or soccer as they call it in this neck of the woods. A desi sales whizkid, now a convert to the American kind of football, was happy to debate whether soccer now occupies a place among the top four

